

**BOISE
GEMS**

**2026
Battery
Technique Manual
& Audition Packet**

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I. INTRODUCTION

Thank you for your interest in the Boise Gems Battery!

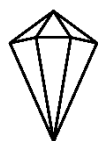
Downloading this packet means that you have taken the first steps into being a part of our 2026 production. Everything you need to know to have a successful season is within this packet. This has been designed to not only make you a better musician, but to make us, the staff, better educators. The following pages describe our approach to the instrument, the language we use, and the exercises we will regularly play.

The success of our ensemble hinges on the professionalism of each individual, both staff and members alike. From the preparation and memorization of the following materials to our conduct in rehearsals, our interactions with others outside of this ensemble, and as we arrive in Dayton, Ohio to perform on the world's biggest stage for this activity, our collective goal is for our achievement to be a direct reflection of our organization's professionalism represented from each one of us.

Our hope is to be a leader in excellence for the greater Boise area, both in our performance and how we carry ourselves representing the Boise Gems Organization.

We are very excited to have your interest in auditioning for this ensemble. We wish you luck and hope to see you soon at one of our many audition clinics.

If you have any questions at any point, feel free to reach out via slack or by email anytime:



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II. Audition Process

In this packet, we have many exercises we may play throughout the season. These exercises are provided to you as a basic foundation of skillsets. We, as a staff, expect our members to be able to achieve these exercises at a high level. What we play throughout the season may change appropriately based on the skillset of our ensemble as the season progresses.

Those who intend to march in the battery should be able to mark time through all of the provided materials. **During the audition process, you will be expected to have the following not only comfortable but memorized.**

Succeeding during the audition process will come from how comfortable you look and sound. Not only do you need to be prepared with a strong sense of fundamentals, but also be prepared to make any adjustments needed. It is just as important for the staff to see your flexibility to new information. The season will be filled with new instructions constantly.

For your audition, please bring your sticks, your drum pad, and a willingness to learn!

Overall, the purpose of the audition process is for you to show off what you are capable of, how well you play with other members of the line, and how well you respond to feedback - we want to see if you will be a good fit for the ensemble. Don't be afraid to ask questions during this process if you don't feel like you understand the directions given to you. We want to see you at your best mind set and make the whole audition process as fair as we can for every member auditioning!

III. The Gems Approach

Relaxed Fulcrum with American Grip



CONTACT WITHOUT PRESSURE

American Grip with all fingers making full contact on the stick without any excess tension.

Keeping our hand shape as similar as possible as we play through different rudimental vocabulary to maintain consistent sound quality.

Hold the stick with a **Soft** touch. Try to make the stick feel **Heavy**.

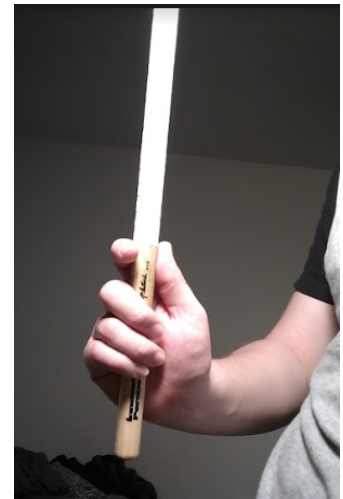
The Fulcrum:

By definition, a point of rotation. For percussionists, the contact point is between our fingers and stick where the stick can easily rotate within our hands.

Typically found a third of the way up from the bottom of the stick.

We utilize the fulcrum with our thumb, index and middle fingers. The thumb and middle finger will supply pressure for diddles/buzzes. The index finger allows the stick to travel in a straight line.

All of our fingers still remain in full contact on the stick. Eliminate any tension while fingers are in contact with the stick. Any whiteness in fingers/joints indicates the stick is held with too much tension.



Relaxed and openness of the hands = relaxed and open sound quality from the drum.

Wrist based motions are easier to achieve while keeping the “*pocket*” (the space between the palm and the base of the stick) closer. Maintaining consistent pockets at any height of rise will allow for more controlled velocity and weight transfer.

Sound Quality

We define sound quality in three components:

1. Height of Rise:
 - How far is the bead of the stick away from the drum head?
2. Velocity:
 - How fast are we moving the stick into the drum?
3. Weight Transfer:
 - How much contact are we allowing the bead to make with the drum?

Using these three factors for any given dynamic allows us to play as efficiently as possible

Height of Rise Definition

A relative definition of stick heights with inches or degrees in relation to the drum head.

3" / 0° = Piano

6" / 30° = Mezzo Piano

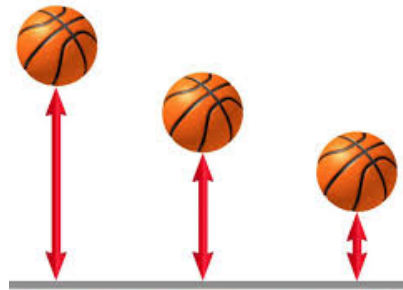
9" / 45° = Mezzo Forte

12" / 60° = Forte

15" / 90° = Fortissimo

Velocity (Wait Longer, Move Faster)

We want to move the stick with enough speed into the drum that it will naturally rebound off the drum head. Similar to how we would dribble a basketball, the faster the ball reaches the ground, the higher the ball will rebound back up without interference. Providing enough velocity through the stick so that the bead rebounds naturally off the drum head. Without interference, supplying higher velocity at 12 inches will return our bead back to 12 inch height contrasted to supplying lower amounts of velocity at 3 inches to rebound back to 3 inch height. Too much velocity will cause the stick to rebound past its original height. If we supply too little velocity, the stick will fail to rebound back to where we started.



Weight Transfer

Defined in two parts, how much contact are we allowing the bead to make with the drum head, and how much of our own weight are we contributing to the motion? The more we “dig in” to the drum, the more weight transfer. Feather tapping would be an example of very low weight transfer.

Snare Drum Technique

The Traditional Grip

Left Hand:

- Back of the stick should rest naturally in the “webby” connection between the thumb and index finger
- Stick rests on the cuticle of the relaxed ring finger
- Pinky rests right underneath the ring finger with no tension.
- The pad of the thumb should connect to the first knuckle of the index finger (connect roughly 1/3 up the stick to match R hand fulcrum)
- Middle finger naturally and gently curves along the stick. Don’t apply pressure to the stick.
- Avoid straightening or opening fingers. When you let your arms and hands dangle to your side, ***your fingers curve naturally***. Continue that natural curve just enough to connect your thumb and index finger, no more. Over-curving or straightening fingers creates tension on the stick
- The back of the hand should create an outward slope leading to the formation of a **straight line from the forearm through the wrist to the tip of the thumb**.
- If it was raining, water should hit your palm, however should not collect within your hand

Correct:

- Thumb aligned with forearm
- Palm slightly turned up
- Wrist relaxed
- Maintaining similar stick angle as matched grip



Incorrect:

- Wrist bent inwards
- Thumb Misaligned with Forearm
- Stick angle too sharp inwards



Snare Drum Technique Cont.

The Form:

- Keep **elbows** close to the body
 - Your right elbow will stick a bit further out than your left arm
 - Avoid using muscle groups above the elbow when playing.
- Keep **shoulders** as aligned
 - Keep the shoulders rolled back and relaxed.

The Right Arm:

- One straight line from elbow to the bead
- Bead led motions
 - As beads increase in height of rise, your wrists will follow, then your arm
- Keeping forearm relaxed to utilize the wrist as efficiently as you can



The Left Arm:

- Forearm bends slightly down.
- Elbow will not move
 - Forearm moves in an up and down motion rather than rotating from elbow
- Keep the wrists low
- The bead of the stick will dictate motions through the drum.
 - Wrists will follow the bead



Tenor Drum Technique

- The tenors will use the ***Match Grip***.
- Whenever possible, we would like to return to “Home base” which is set position above drums 1 and 2.
- When moving across drums, your technique does **NOT** change. Application of the matched grip technique on one drum translates to all other drums.

HOME ZONE



Beads are slightly outside the center of the drum

PROPER STICK ALIGNMENT

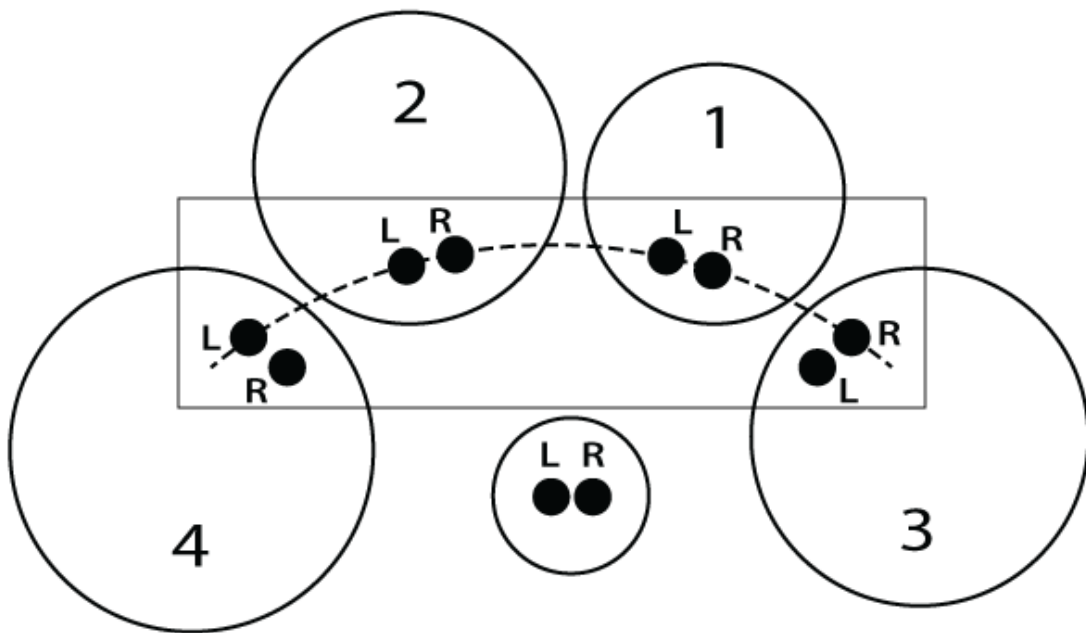
VS

INCORRECT STICK ALIGNMENT



Tenor Drum Technique Cont.

- The path that the sticks travel across different drums is contained in a linear box.
 - Timbre (where the bead hits the head) is vital for good tonal quality.
 - Utilize the bead of the stick to dictate alignment.
 - Sticks move across drums in a “windshield wiper” motion.



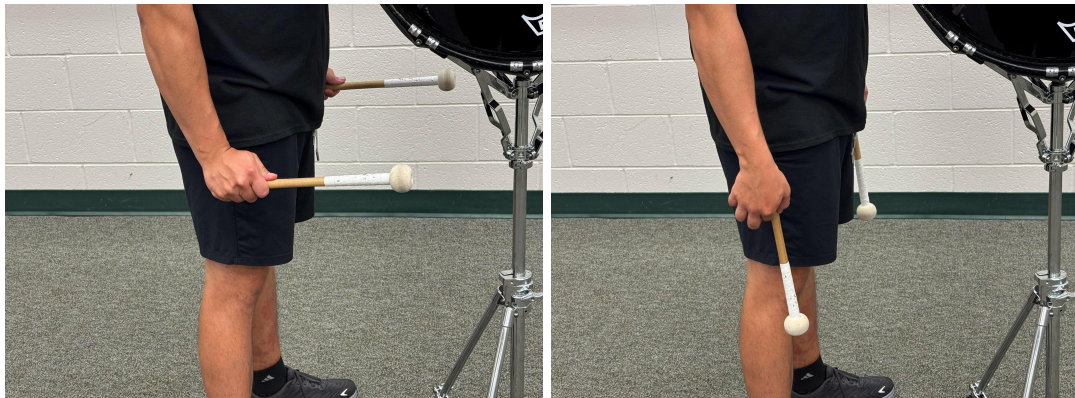
Bass Drum Technique

The Fulcrum:

- Generally speaking, the hand will be slightly more spread out than a typically horizontal match grip technique
 - Start with hand palm facing up
 - Place mallet across hand making contact points near bottom of pointer finger and pad of palm
 - Close hand, with least amount of tension possible, but just enough to support weight of mallet
 - This will create closer to a 3 finger fulcrum as opposed to a traditional 2 finger fulcrum to allow for more control of a mallet that will have more weight

The Form:

- Start with mallets down and relaxed down at the sides
- If mallet weight is supported properly in the hand, that will create a **natural** angle (this might vary from player to player)
 - Incorrect:



Correct:



- The relationship from **elbow**, to **wrist**, to **bead** of mallet should remain the same as we bring mallets up to a playing position
- Generally speaking, players should aim to pivot from elbow until forearm is horizontal or parallel to the ground



- Adjustments might need to be made depending on size of drum without sacrificing previous relationship established from elbow to bead of mallet
 - Smaller drums might need the arm to be pulled back away from drum
 - Larger drums might need the arm to be pushed towards the drum
- Similar to a horizontal match grip, there should be one straight line from elbow to bead of mallet
 - Instead of a downward line, there should be a slightly **inward** line from elbow to head of drum
 - CAUTION: Beware of flaring elbows out too far. The goal is to play with the thicker part of the head of the mallet for best sound quality production



- Bass head's center, and subsequently the drum height, should be adjusted to where the head of the mallet is aligned after establishing the above mentioned form
- Keep **shoulders** as aligned (square)
 - Shoulders stay rolled back and relaxed
- Keep yourself **Tall** and **Broad**
 - Alignment from ankle to head, the "body line"
- "Match Grip" but moving horizontally rather than vertically (Wrist Break)
 - Stick's path will be led by the head of the mallet
 - Bead lead motion towards the drum head in a horizontal plane
 - Perpendicular motion to avoid slicing motion.
 - Allow for mallet to breathe in hand between the back three fingers and palm
 - Utilize the back three fingers for optimal control of mallet



BGI Fundamentals 2026

8 on a hand

Handbell exercise 1: 8 on a hand. Measures 1-5. Rhythmic pattern: 8 eighth notes. Hand alternation: R → L → R → L → R.

Down/Ups

Handbell exercise 2: Down/Ups. Measures 6-10. Rhythmic pattern: 8 eighth notes. Hand alternation: R → L → R → L → R. Dynamics: *f* → *p* → *f* → *p* → *f*.

Up/Downs

Handbell exercise 3: Up/Downs. Measures 11-15. Rhythmic pattern: 8 eighth notes. Hand alternation: R → L → R → L → R. Dynamics: *p* → *f* → *p* → *f* → *p*.

Bucks

Handbell exercise 4: Bucks. Measures 16-20. Rhythmic pattern: 8 eighth notes. Hand alternation: R → L → R → L → R. Accents: > > > > > > > >.

Double Accent

Handbell exercise 5: Double Accent. Measures 21-25. Rhythmic pattern: 8 eighth notes. Hand alternation: R → L → R → L → R. Accents: > > > > > > > >.

Every Three

Handbell exercise 6: Every Three. Measures 26-30. Rhythmic pattern: 8 eighth notes. Hand alternation: R → L → R → L → R. Accents: > > > > > > > >.

Triplet Timing 1 Note

Handbell exercise 7: Triplet Timing 1 Note. Measures 31-34. Rhythmic pattern: 12 eighth notes (4 groups of 3). Hand alternation: R L cont. → R → R L cont. → L →.

Handbell exercise 8: Continuation of Triplet Timing 1 Note. Measures 35-37. Rhythmic pattern: 12 eighth notes (4 groups of 3). Hand alternation: R L cont. → R → R L cont. → L → R.

Triplet Timing 2 Note

38 39 40

R L cont. R L L R R L L R R L cont.

41 42 43

L R R L L R R L R L cont. R R L L R R L L

44 45 46

R L cont. R L L R R L cont. L R R L R L cont. R R L L

47 48 49 50

R L R L R R L R R L R L R L L R

Double Beat

51 52 53 54

R → L → L → L →

55 56 57 58

R → L → R → L →

59 60 61 62

R → L → L → L →

63 64 65 66

R → L → R → L →

67 68 69 70

R → L → L → L →

71 72 73 74 75

R → L → R → L → R

76 **Gallop** 77 78 79

R L cont.

80 81 82 83 84

85 **Triplet Rolls** 86 87

R | r L r | R | r L r | r | r | r | r | r | r | r | cont.

88 89 90

91 92 93

94 95 96 97

R

98 **Sixteenth Note Grid** 99 100

R | r | R | r | R | r | R | r | cont.

101 102 103

104 105 106

R

Triplet Note Grid

107 108 109

R | r L r | R | r L r | cont.

110 111 112

113 114 115 116 117

R

7/8 Paradiddles Variations*Var. 1: Skeleton*

118 119 120 121

R r L | R r | R r L | R r | R r L | R r L | R r L |

Var. 2: Herta

122 123 124 125

R | r L r | R | r | R | r L r | R | r | R | r L r | R | r | R | r L r |

Var. 3: Tap Buzz

126 127 128 129

R r L | R r | R r L | R r | R r L | R r L | R r L |

Var. 4: Tap Diddle

130 131 132 133

R r L | R r | R r L | R r | R r L | R r L | R r L |

Var. 5: Para-Buzz

134 135 136 137

R | r L r | R | r | R | r L r | R | r | R | r L r | R | r | R | r L r |

Var. 6 Paradiddles

138 139 140 141 142

R | r r L r | R | r r | R | r r L r | R | r r | R | r r L r | R | r r | R | r r L r |

All 3 variations meant to be played consecutively

146

149

152

155

158

161

164

166

SCV Stick Control

Murray Gusseck
trans/arr: Taha Ahmed

SCV Stick Control

Murray Gusseck
trans/arr: Taha Ahmed

Variation 1

RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RRRLRRRLRRRLRRRL RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLLLRLLLRLLLRLLL

Variation 2

RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RRRLRRRLRRRLRRRL RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLLLRLLLRLLLRLLL

Variation 3

RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RRRLRRRLRRRLRRRL RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLLLRLLLRLLLRLLL

Variation 4

RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RRRLRRRLRRRLRRRL RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLLLRLLLRLLLRLLL

Variation 5

RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RRRLRRRLRRRLRRRL RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLLLRLLLRLLLRLLL

5

Variation 1

RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RRRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLLLRLLLRLLLRLLL

Variation 2

RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RRRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLLLRLLLRLLLRLLL

Variation 3

RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RRRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLLLRLLLRLLLRLLL

Variation 4

RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RRRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLLLRLLLRLLLRLLL

Variation 5

RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RRRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLLLRLLLRLLLRLLL R R

9

Variation 1

RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RRRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLLLRLLLRLLLRLLL

Variation 2

RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RRRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLLLRLLLRLLLRLLL

Variation 3

RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RRRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLLLRLLLRLLLRLLL

Variation 4

RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RRRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLLLRLLLRLLLRLLL

Variation 5

RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RRRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLRLRLRLRLRLRLRL RLLLRLLLRLLLRLLL

[illegible][illegible]

7

Variation 1
R L R L R L R L R L R L R L R L R R L L R R L L R R L L R R R L r L r L r L

Variation 2
R RR L L R R L

Variation 3
R R r L L L R R R R R R R L R R L R L R

10

The musical score for Exercise 10 consists of three staves. The top staff uses a simplified rhythmic notation with horizontal lines and diagonal slashes, with fingerings R R R L R R R L R L L L R L L L and R R R R L L L L R R L L R R L L R. The middle staff uses standard musical notation with eighth and sixteenth notes, including accents (>) and a final R. The bottom staff also uses standard musical notation with eighth and sixteenth notes, including accents (>) and fingerings R L L L L L R R R R L R L L L R.